

how a chunk of silver in a bank box helped burn victims, but Handleman's method directed that she would resell when the market for silver went up, as it was sure to, and that her profit would enable her to turn around and invest in other worthy commodities.

Penny hadn't spent her entire cash advance on silver. She meant to pay the remaining amount right back into her card, but never quite got around to it. She left it in her checking account and, when it was gone, couldn't fully account for its disappearance. Well, she had upgraded the sound system in her car to make the commute more comfortable ... and she had nearly paid off one of her smaller department store cards. Telling herself she was choosing wisely, she had taken advantage of a big-box store's computer sale and selected just the laptop she needed. She had treated herself to a lavish "girls' getaway spa package" for a weekend with some friends from church ... Yes, she was sure all that money hadn't been wasted. And of course there was the bullion in her safe box.

One weekend, when Penny was unexpectedly home on a Saturday evening, she decided to try out the budgeting software she had purchased around the time she had started her new job, but that she had never installed. As she went through her accounts, she was appalled to see laid out right on her computer screen how much she owed in comparison to what she was making monthly. Somehow it had never dawned on her that she was spending far more than she brought in, or else had never allowed the realization to take root.

Penny searched for "debt reduction," entered her zip code, found several companies that offered services, and chose the one whose name seemed the most interesting. She e-mailed for an appointment.